

Owning the Internet with Python and Requests

Python modules for sending HTTP requests can be cumbersome. While the inbuilt Python module has HTTP capabilities, the problem lies with the broken APIs. It requires tremendous effort to overcome this drawback. In this article, learn how to access Web APIs, download files and make HTTP requests with Requests - a handy Python library that makes the job as easy as it should have been!



Python is a scripting language with so much power that it's actually used as a general-purpose programming language. It is so natural that it is easy to learn. And so high-level that it's very easy to perform complex functions with it, using just a few lines of code. And yet, to interact with the Internet with the standard library, you have to jump through many hoops.

Surely, interacting with the Internet in Python could be a lot easier, a lot more 'Pythonic'? Well, there's a library called Requests, and it does just that.

Getting Started

Before using Requests, you need to download it. If you're in a virtual environment, you can just use *pip* to do the job for you, as follows:

```
$: pip install requests
```

For installing Requests system-wide, you can check if your distro has a package. 'Requests' is available for both Python 2 and Python 3, so download the correct package.

Let's start with the basics. To import Requests, run the following command:

```
>>> import requests
```

Start with a simple GET request. You will get Google's home page:

```
>>> r = requests.get("https://www.google.com")
>>> r.status_code
200
>>> r.headers["content-type"]
'text/html; charset=ISO-8859-1'
>>> r.encoding
```